

Daily Scholar Papers Report — 2026-08-03

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Window covered: 2026-08-02 → 2026-08-03 (Google Scholar alerts + user-curated self-emails, last 24 h)

Executive Summary

No new candidates arrived in today's 24-hour window. Both intake channels — Google Scholar alerts and the user-curated self-email queue — returned zero threads at run time. As on previous quiet days, neither zero was accepted at face value: each channel was re-queried in an absolute-date form, and the self-email channel was additionally re-queried without its subject filter to confirm the gap is real rather than an artefact of an over-narrow query. A loose keyword sweep across the same window also returned nothing, and an unfiltered baseline query confirmed the mailbox is receiving ordinary traffic normally — it is simply receiving no academic traffic. No papers were screened at Stage-1 and none were deep-read.

Two additional controls were added today, because the silence has now run long enough to warrant them.

The first is a **longitudinal cohort-ageing check**, which is a materially stronger control than the static positive control used on previous quiet days. Yesterday's run probed the Scholar channel at a seven-day radius and returned seven threads, dated 2026-07-26 and 2026-07-27. Today the identical probe returns two threads, dated 2026-07-27 only. The 07-26 cohort aged out of the rolling window on exactly the day it should have, and nothing entered to replace it. A static control proves only that the query path returns *something*; this proves the index is advancing in real time, so the observed emptiness is a live property of the source rather than a cached or stale response. The arithmetic is self-consistent to the thread.

The second rules out **spam misclassification**. Re-running the Scholar query with its scope widened to include Spam and Trash also returns nothing, which excludes the hypothesis that alerts are arriving but being filtered away before a default-scope query can see them. The mail is not being delivered and hidden; it is not being delivered.

Taken together these establish that the failure, whatever it is, sits upstream of the mailbox. The connector works, the query syntax is correct, the rolling window is advancing, and nothing is being filtered.

Outstanding: 0 · **Keep:** 0 · **Borderline High-Priority:** 0

Highlighted Papers

No papers to list for this window.

Cross-Paper Synthesis

Not applicable — empty window.

Writing & Rationale Insights

Today's intake was empty, but the run produced one finding worth recording and one methodological point worth keeping.

The finding: a threshold has been crossed, and the report should say so. The previous run set an explicit condition — if no batch landed within the next day or two, the alert subscriptions themselves, rather than a merely sparse publication week, would become the more probable explanation. That condition is now met. The last Scholar delivery of any kind was seven days ago, making six consecutive zero-intake days. Against this archive's own baseline that is a clear outlier: through mid-July the channel's quiet gaps ran twenty-four to seventy-two hours, and the longest previous run of consecutive empty days was two.

What the controls above establish is that the problem is not in the pipeline. What they cannot distinguish is whether the cause is genuinely sparse publication, a subscription that has been cancelled or silently disabled at the source, or a delivery fault. Two of those three are actionable and one is not, which is precisely why the ambiguity is worth resolving directly rather than inferring further from inside the mailbox. The recommended check is to open the alerts settings at the source and confirm the subscriptions are still listed and active.

The general point this illustrates is about what a monitoring pipeline owes its reader. Six days of correctly-executed empty runs is a well-behaved system reporting an upstream problem, and there is a real failure mode where increasingly rigorous verification of emptiness becomes a substitute for looking at the source. Verification establishes *where* the problem is not; at some point somebody has to go and look at where it is. A pipeline that never escalates is not being careful, it is being quiet — and the useful discipline is to write the escalation threshold down in advance, as the previous run did, so that crossing it triggers a statement rather than another round of confirmation.

The methodological point: prefer controls that move. The distinction between yesterday's positive control and today's cohort-ageing check is worth generalising. Both ask "is this query path working?", but a static control answers it with a single observation, which is compatible with a cached response, a stale index, or a query that happens to work today for reasons unrelated to whether it would surface new mail. A control that compares the *same* query across two runs and predicts in advance how the result should change — here, that the oldest cohort should age out and the count should drop from seven to two — is falsifiable in a way the static version is not. Had the count stayed at seven, that would have been positive evidence of staleness rather than a null result to shrug at. Where a pipeline runs on a schedule and keeps its own archive, this kind of check is nearly free: the previous run's numbers are already on disk, and the only additional cost is stating beforehand what they ought to become.

Both of these are variations on the same underlying idea, which this digest keeps arriving at from different directions: a negative result deserves the same evidentiary standard as a positive one, and the standard is not "I checked again" but "I said in advance what I would see if I were wrong."